

Goal Writing Guide

Functional · Measurable · Time-bound · By diagnosis · SNF Therapy · 2026

The SMART Framework for Therapy Goals

S	Specific	Name the exact functional task — not "improve strength" but "perform sit-to-stand transfer"
M	Measurable	Include a level of assist, distance, repetitions, or standardized score
A	Achievable	Realistic given the patient's diagnosis, prior level of function, and rehab potential
R	Relevant	Tied directly to the patient's functional goals and discharge plan
T	Time-bound	State the timeframe — "in 2 weeks" or "by discharge" — for every goal

Weak vs Strong — Fix These Common Goal Mistakes

✗ Weak Goal	✓ Strong Goal
<i>Patient will improve strength.</i>	<i>Patient will perform sit-to-stand from standard chair height with min A x1 for 5 reps in 2 weeks.</i>
<i>Patient will improve balance.</i>	<i>Patient will ambulate 150 ft with FWW and CGA on level surfaces without loss of balance in 2 weeks.</i>
<i>Patient will improve ADL function.</i>	<i>Patient will complete upper body dressing with min A and verbal cues for sequencing in 2 weeks.</i>
<i>Patient will improve swallowing.</i>	<i>Patient will safely consume nectar-thick liquids with chin tuck technique with min verbal cues, 0 s/s aspiration in 2 weeks.</i>
<i>Patient will increase independence.</i>	<i>Patient will perform bed-to-WC transfer with supervision only using correct technique in 10 days.</i>
<i>Patient will improve communication.</i>	<i>Patient will produce functional 3-word phrases to communicate basic needs with 80% accuracy in 2 weeks.</i>

Assist Level Reference — Use These in Every Goal

Independent (I)	No assistance needed. Patient safe and consistent without any cues or help.
Supervision (S)	Therapist present for safety but provides no physical or verbal assistance.
Contact Guard Assist (CGA)	Therapist hands on but providing no force — ready to assist if needed.
Min Assist (Min A)	Patient performs 75%+ of the task. Therapist provides light support or steadying.
Mod Assist (Mod A)	Patient performs 50–74% of the task. Therapist provides moderate support.
Max Assist (Max A)	Patient performs 25–49% of the task. Therapist provides majority of effort.
Dependent (D)	Patient performs less than 25%. Therapist performs most or all of the task.

Goal Examples by Diagnosis

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PT — Hip Fracture / Post-Surgical

- Patient will perform bed-to-WC transfer with min A, maintaining WBAT precautions in 1 week.
- Patient will ambulate 100 ft with FWW and min A on level surfaces in 2 weeks.
- Patient will negotiate 4 stairs with rail and CGA in 3 weeks.
- Patient will demonstrate HEP independently with correct technique prior to discharge.

PT — Generalized Deconditioning

- Patient will ambulate 200 ft with FWW and supervision on level surfaces in 2 weeks.
- Patient will perform 5 sit-to-stands independently with correct technique in 2 weeks.
- Patient will demonstrate functional endurance for 10-minute activity tolerance in 2 weeks.
- Patient will negotiate community curbs with CGA in 3 weeks.

OT — Cognitive Impairment / Dementia

- Patient will complete 3-step ADL task with mod A and 2 verbal cues for sequencing in 2 weeks.
- Patient will demonstrate safe meal setup and initiation with supervision in 10 days.
- Patient will participate in familiar daily routine with min verbal redirection in 2 weeks.
- Patient will use compensatory memory strategy (whiteboard/list) with min A in 2 weeks.

ST — Aphasia / Language

- Patient will produce functional 3-word phrases for basic needs with 80% accuracy in 2 weeks.
- Patient will follow 2-step verbal instructions with min verbal cues in 10 days.
- Patient will use AAC/communication board to express needs with min A in 2 weeks.
- Patient will demonstrate word retrieval for high-frequency nouns with 70% accuracy in 2 weeks.

PT — CVA / Hemiplegia

- Patient will perform sit-to-stand with mod A and verbal cues for weight shifting in 2 weeks.
- Patient will ambulate 50 ft with hemi-walker and min A, demonstrating improved gait pattern in 2 weeks.
- Patient will demonstrate functional weight-bearing tolerance on affected LE for transfers with min A in 10 days.
- Patient will perform standing balance tasks with UE support for 30 seconds in 2 weeks.

OT — CVA / UE Hemiplegia

- Patient will complete upper body dressing with min A and verbal cues for sequencing in 2 weeks.
- Patient will perform grooming tasks seated at sink with supervision in 10 days.
- Patient will demonstrate functional use of affected UE as assist during bilateral tasks in 2 weeks.
- Patient will complete bathing with mod A using adaptive equipment in 2 weeks.

ST — Dysphagia

- Patient will safely consume nectar-thick liquids with chin tuck, 0 overt s/s aspiration in 2 weeks.
- Patient will tolerate minced & moist diet texture with mod A for meal setup in 10 days.
- Patient will demonstrate correct effortful swallow technique with min verbal cues in 2 weeks.
- Patient will complete oral care routine independently prior to each meal in 10 days.

ST — Cognitive Communication

- Patient will demonstrate orientation x3 with min verbal cues in 10 days.
- Patient will complete functional attention task for 10 minutes with min redirection in 2 weeks.
- Patient will demonstrate problem-solving for 2-step daily living tasks with mod A in 2 weeks.
- Patient will recall 3/5 items after 10-minute delay with compensatory strategy in 2 weeks.

The 5 Golden Rules: (1) Every goal must name a specific functional task. (2) Include assist level OR measurable performance metric. (3) State a timeframe — always. (4) Goals must connect to the patient's discharge environment. (5) Update goals when met or when the patient's status changes — never leave outdated goals in the chart.